Burma's intellectuals. Before the 1962 coup, Burma had one of the highest living standards in Southeast Asia and a fairly well-educated population. Afterward, its prosperity fled along with its best and brightest.

In 1963, banks in Burma were nationalized. The Burmese could only hold one account in one bank with each account having not more than a balance of kyat 10,000 per month or kyat 50,000 per year. Account holders could make withdrawals of kyat 5; however, they were only permitted to make a maximum of two withdrawals per week.

As part of their economic programme, the Ne Win government demonetized the kyat thrice, each time with little or no compensation. Woefully, each demonetization failed and only compounded the economic distress of the people, leading to a situation where citizens had little faith in their currency or banks, and chose instead to keep their savings in gold, jewellery, or land.

1964 The Demonetization Act of 1964 declared 50 and 100 Burmese kyat illegal overnight. These notes were to be surrendered at receiving centres within a week. Reimbursement was offered in varying time frames depending on the amount. However, any amounts deposited over kyat 4,200 would be scrutinized and subjected to tax. The redemption deadline was repeatedly extended and when it finally ended four months later, only about 78 per cent of the notes were returned. Due to both logistical problems and also fears of tax scrutiny, many Burmese did not exchange their notes. Both the kyat 50 and 100 notes were reintroduced later.

1985 On 3 November 1985, the 20, 50, and 100 kyat notes were demonetized without warning. kyat 25, 35 and 75 notes were introduced in their place. Limits to cash deposits and deadlines similar to the 1964 demonetization were set – with similar unhappy results for the people. In an act of expropriation rarely seen before, only 25 per cent of cash surrendered was reimbursed.

1987 Two years later, on 5 September 1987, Ne Win announced Myanmar's third demonetization, without warning or compensation.